

"within 24 hours of Musharraf resigning or being impeached". In addition, he had also promised that, unless the 17th amendment was repealed by the Parliament—the constitutional amendment that indemnified Musharraf's coup in 1999 and restored presidential powers to dismiss Parliament and to appoint the military chiefs—a "non-political" figure of "national stature" would be nominated jointly by the coalition partners for the position of the President. Sounding terribly hurt, and expressing his sadness, Sharif pointed out that Zardari had gone against these agreements, first by delaying the restoration of the judiciary and then by having himself unilaterally nominated for the presidency.

In fact, it was the latter action by Zardari that broke the proverbial camel's back. "Will someone please tell Asif Zardari that 58(2b) does not mean 58.2 billion dollars!" The jokes began flying on mobile text messages even before Benazir Bhutto's widower had announced his "acceptance" on August 23 of his party's nomination of himself as a candidate for the newly-created

vacancy in the post of Pakistan's presidency. This particular joke referred not only to Zardari's alleged financial wrongdoings—charges which were never conclusively proven and which he has now been absolved of, under the controversial National Reconciliation Ordinance (NRO) promulgated by former president, General Musharraf—

By pulling out, Sharif took a calculated gamble. He knows that his personal popularity is on the rise by sticking to 'principles'.

but also to the infamous constitutional clause 58(2b) that confers on the President the powers to dissolve the elected National Assembly.

But the widespread public shock at the prospect of "President Zardari"—a prospect that had begun to gain momentum within the political allies of the PPP within three days of Musharraf's

resignation—does not take away from the fact that, at least in the short term, Zardari has outmanoeuvred his opponents, including his "ally in democracy", Sharif. Not only has he managed to oust Musharraf—a strongman whose shadow always hung over the elected Government—he has struck deals with all the powers that matter, leaving Sharif isolated. Once Sharif realised that he was not going to get his way with Zardari, he played his trump card—pulling his party out of the coalition. But, by then Zardari had shored up enough support from the smaller parties—and with the US backing him for now—that the PPP almost did not bat an eyelid at the falling apart of their coalition.

Sharif has taken a calculated political gamble. He realises that his popularity graph is on the way up "for sticking to his principles" which may pay off handsome dividends in future polls. He also realises that the kind of issues being faced by the Government—serious economic problems as well as a divisive internal war against militancy that will require un-



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